The First Home Buyer's 90-Day Checklist — Victoria

Everything you need to sort before you sign, in plain English.

Correct as at July 2026. Grant amounts, price caps and eligibility rules are set by government and can change — always confirm current details with the State Revenue Office (sro.vic.gov.au) or your lender before relying on this for a purchase decision. This checklist is general information, not financial or legal advice.

How to use this checklist

Work through the five sections in order. Section 1 you can start today, for free, before you've even found a property. Sections 2–5 apply once you're actively looking, have made an offer, and are heading toward settlement. Tick items off as you go — there's a note next to each one on *why* it matters, not just *what* to do.

Section 1 — Get Your Foundations Right (Do this first, before house-hunting)

- [ ] **Check your borrowing capacity with 2–3 lenders or a mortgage broker.** Your borrowing power varies more between lenders than most people expect — a broker can shop this for you at no direct cost (they're paid by the lender).
- [ ] **Work out your real deposit target.** A standard deposit is 20% of the purchase price to avoid Lenders Mortgage Insurance (LMI) — but see the First Home Guarantee below, which can let you buy with just 5% deposit and no LMI if you're eligible.
- [ ] **Check if you qualify for the federal First Home Guarantee.** Since October 2025 there are no income caps and no annual place limits. Price caps are **$950,000 for Melbourne and Geelong**, and **$650,000 for the rest of Victoria**. If eligible, you can buy with a 5% deposit while avoiding LMI entirely — a significant saving.
- [ ] **Check your eligibility for the Victorian First Home Owner Grant (FHOG).** This is a **one-off $10,000 payment**, but only for a **new home** (never previously lived in or sold) valued at **$750,000 or less**, including land. It does *not* apply to established (existing) homes. You (and your partner, if applicable) must never have owned and lived in residential property in Australia before, and at least one applicant must be an Australian citizen, permanent resident, or eligible NZ citizen. You must move in within 12 months of settlement and live there continuously for at least 12 months, or you may have to repay the grant.
- [ ] **Check stamp duty exemptions/concessions — these apply even if you're buying an established home.** Victoria gives a **full stamp duty exemption** for first home buyers on properties valued **under $600,000**, and a **sliding-scale concession** for properties between **$600,000 and $750,000**. This is separate from the FHOG and is often the bigger saving.
- [ ] **If buying off-the-plan, check the off-the-plan duty concession.** This has been extended to eligible contracts signed **on or before 21 October 2026**, including (since October 2024) some investment purchases of apartments/townhouses in strata schemes — worth checking even if you're not a first home buyer.
- [ ] **Consider the First Home Super Saver Scheme (FHSSS)** if you're still building your deposit — it lets you save inside superannuation for tax benefits. Ask your accountant or broker whether it suits your timeline.
- [ ] **Understand the federal Help to Buy shared equity scheme**, launched December 2025 (replacing the older Victorian Homebuyer Fund) — under this scheme the government can co-invest with you, reducing how much you need to borrow. Check current eligibility, as shared-equity schemes usually have income and price caps.
- [ ] **Get pre-approval, not just a "borrowing capacity estimate."** Formal pre-approval strengthens your negotiating position and tells you your real, lender-verified budget before you start making offers.

Section 2 — While You're Searching

- [ ] **Set a firm maximum price** based on your pre-approval, not what you emotionally want to spend at an open home.
- [ ] **Budget for costs beyond the purchase price**: conveyancing/legal fees, building & pest inspections, loan application/valuation fees, moving costs, and immediate setup costs (utility connections, locks). These regularly add up to several thousand dollars beyond the deposit.
- [ ] **Decide whether you're buying at auction or private sale** — this matters hugely for your legal protections (see Section 3).
- [ ] **Research the suburb, not just the property**: check comparable recent sale prices, planned developments nearby, flood/overlay zones, and public transport if relevant to you.

Section 3 — Know Your Legal Protections Before You Sign

- [ ] **Understand the cooling-off period — and its limits.** For **private sales** of residential property in Victoria, you generally get **3 clear business days** after signing to withdraw from the contract, for any reason, without needing to prove fault. "Clear business days" excludes weekends and public holidays, and the day you sign doesn't count — so if you sign Monday, your window is Tuesday–Thursday.
- [ ] **Know when cooling-off does *not* apply**: it does **not** apply if you buy at **auction**, or if you sign within 3 clear business days *before or after* a publicly advertised auction for that property. It also doesn't apply to company/corporate purchases or large rural land (20+ hectares). If you're buying at auction, there is **no cooling-off period at all** — you're committed the moment the hammer falls, which is why pre-auction building/pest inspections and finance approval are non-negotiable.
- [ ] **Know the cost of changing your mind.** If you do cool off during the window, you'll pay a penalty of **$100 or 0.2% of the purchase price, whichever is greater** (e.g. $1,600 on an $800,000 property).
- [ ] **Get a building and pest inspection before you're legally committed** — before signing for a private sale, or before auction day if buying at auction. This is a separate product in this series (Checklist #2) — treat it as essential, not optional, regardless of how "renovated" a property looks.
- [ ] **Have a conveyancer or solicitor review the Contract of Sale and Section 32 (Vendor's Statement) before you sign anything.** The Section 32 discloses things like zoning, easements, owners corporation fees, and any notices/orders affecting the property — this is where costly surprises hide.

Section 4 — Between Signing and Settlement

- [ ] [ ] **Arrange building insurance from the moment you exchange contracts** (not from settlement) — in Victoria, risk can pass to the buyer earlier than settlement day depending on your contract terms; confirm this with your conveyancer.
- [ ] [ ] **Finalise unconditional loan approval** and satisfy any remaining lender conditions well before settlement date.
- [ ] [ ] **Book a pre-settlement inspection** in the days before settlement to confirm the property is in the agreed condition and any included items (fittings, appliances) are still there.
- [ ] [ ] **Organise your conveyancer to handle the FHOG paperwork** if applicable — most lenders/conveyancers submit this for you as part of settlement, but confirm who's responsible so it isn't missed. If nobody lodges it for you, you can apply directly to the SRO within 12 months of settlement.

(Full pre-settlement and moving-day logistics are covered in Checklist #3 of this series.)

Section 5 — Common First-Home-Buyer Mistakes to Avoid

- [ ] [ ] **Don't assume the FHOG applies to an established home** — it's new-builds only. Many first-time buyers confuse the FHOG with the stamp duty exemption, which *does* apply to established homes.
- [ ] [ ] **Don't skip the inspection to "save money" on a home you love** — this is consistently where first home buyers lose the most money after settlement.
- [ ] [ ] **Don't bid at auction without unconditional finance approval** — there's no cooling-off period to fall back on.
- [ ] [ ] **Don't forget to budget for the 12-month residency requirement** if claiming the FHOG or stamp duty concession — renting the property out too early can trigger repayment obligations.
- [ ] [ ] **Don't rely on this checklist alone for your specific situation** — property, tax and legal circumstances vary. Use this as your framework, then confirm specifics with a conveyancer, mortgage broker, and the SRO before you sign.

Quick Reference — Victoria First Home Buyer Support (July 2026)

SUPPORT	AMOUNT / DETAIL	APPLIES TO
First Home Owner Grant (FHOG)	$10,000 one-off	New homes only, ≤$750,000
Stamp duty exemption	Full exemption	Established or new homes, ≤$600,000
Stamp duty concession	Sliding scale	Established or new homes, $600,000–$750,000
Off-the-plan duty concession	Reduces dutiable value	Eligible contracts signed on/before 21 Oct 2026
First Home Guarantee (federal)	5% deposit, no LMI	≤$950,000 Melbourne/Geelong, ≤$650,000 regional VIC
Help to Buy (federal)	Government co-investment	Income/price caps apply — check current eligibility
Cooling-off period	3 clear business days	Private sales only, not auctions

Sources: State Revenue Office Victoria (sro.vic.gov.au), vic.gov.au, Sale of Land Act 1962 (Vic). Always verify current figures before making a purchase decision — these settings are reviewed periodically by government.